

Session 20: Abraham Endangers Sarah Again

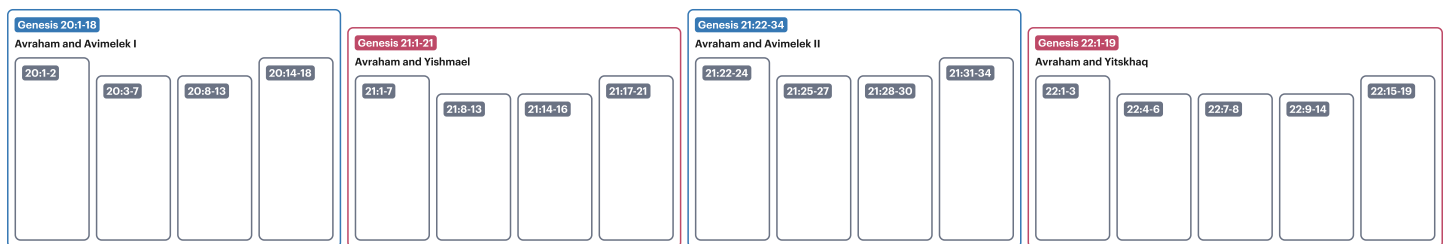
Key Takeaways

- Genesis 20:1-22:19 deals with the unresolved tension over the promised seed.
- Avraham chooses deception once again, so Avimelek acts as his own intercessor.
- The Hebrew Bible regularly critiques its own human heroes, providing a realistic portrait of the people God chooses to work with.

Movement II: Yitskhaq's Birth and the Division of the Family

There are four stories that make up the next main literary unit in Genesis 20:1-22:19.

Macro Design of Genesis 20:1-22:19



Genesis 20:1-22:19. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Thematic Unity

Now that the subplot of Lot's problematic presence has been addressed (from [Gen. 12:4](#) to [chapter 19](#)), there are still other themes in Avraham's story that need to be resolved.

- The promise of a chosen son who will be named "Yitskhaq" (from [Gen. 17-18](#)).
- The problematic presence of Hagar and Yishmael, whom Sarah doesn't like (from [Gen. 16](#)).
- The question of how Avraham is going to become a blessing to the nations around him ([Gen. 12, 14](#)).
- The promise that Avraham will inherit the land of the Canaanites ([Gen. 12, 13, 15, 17](#)).

Compositional Unity

These four stories are arranged in a symmetrical pattern, inviting the reader to relate the stories to one another and compare and contrast them.

Genesis 20:1-18

Avraham and King Avimelek: Round 1

- **20:13** Avraham asks Sarah to deceive others as an act of loyal love (חסד).
- **20:9-10** Avraham deceives Avimelek who disputes with him over the treachery.
- **20:16** Avimelek gives money to Avraham and Sarah to resolve what is disputed (יכח).
- **20:14** Avimelek “took flocks and herds ... and he gave them to Avraham.”

Genesis 21:1-21

Yitskhaq is born; Avraham loses his son to the wilderness

- **21:12-13** God allows the exile of Yishmael and Hagar.
- **21:14** Avraham rose early (וישכם) and took a water skin, setting it upon her shoulder.
- **21:17** The angel of Yahweh comes to rescue in the last minute.
- **21:15, 19** God spares Yishmael, who is under (תחת) a bush, by providing water.

Genesis 21:22-34

Avraham and King Avimelek: Round 2

- **21:23** Avimelek makes Avraham swear that he will act with loyal love (חסד).
- **21:25-27** Avraham thinks he’s been deceived and disputes with Avimelek over a stolen well.

Genesis 22:1-19

Yitskhaq is to die; Avraham loses and then regains his son

- **22:2** God asks Avraham to offer up Yitskhaq.
- **22:3, 6** Avraham rose early (וישכם) ... placing the wood upon Yitskhaq.
- **22:11** The angel of Yahweh comes to rescue in the last minute.
- **22:13** God spares Yitskhaq with a “ram” in the thicket that is offered “in his place” (תחת).

Genesis 20:1-22:19 (Detailed). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Placement Within the Avraham Story as a Whole

The four stories in this unit have also been designed with an eye toward its arrangement. It is curious upon a first reading, until we realize that the stories have been organized to correspond to the sequence of stories in the previous large literary unit of the Avraham stories.

11:27-14:24			15:1-17:27			18:1-19:29		
11:27-12:5	12:6-13:18	14:1-24	15:1-21	16:1-16	17:1-27	18:1-15	18:16-33	19:1-29
12:10-20 Avram Deceives Pharaoh Re: Sarai			Sarah Exiles Hagar Because of Pregnancy			Avraham Chosen for Blessing to Nations on a High Place, Avraham Intercedes With Yahweh on Behalf of Sinful Sodom		
20:1-18 Avraham Deceives Avimelek Re: Sarah			21:1-21 Sarah Exiles Hagar and Yishma'el			21:22-34 Avimelek Makes a Covenant with Avraham, God's Chosen One 22:1-19 On a High Place, Avraham Offers a Sacrifice for His Sins		

Placement of Parts Within the Avraham Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The story in [Genesis 20:1-18](#) is a clear replay of [12:10-20](#). In both stories, Avraham lies about Sarah being his sister, which results in her being taken by a foreign king. The innocence of both kings is highlighted, as is Avraham's guilt for the deception.

The story in [Genesis 21:1-21](#) is essentially part two of the Sarah versus Hagar rivalry. Now that Yitskhaq (Isaac) is born, the presence of Yishmael is a threat to Sarah. And so Hagar finds herself exiled once again, and once again God comes to her in the wilderness and provides rescue in the form of water.

The two stories in [Genesis 21:22-34](#) and [22:1-19](#) are connected to the episode of Avraham's intercession on behalf of the righteous in Sodom. In [Genesis 18:17-19](#), Yahweh speaks to himself about how he chose Avraham to be the vehicle of divine blessing to the nations. In the episode of [Genesis 21:22-34](#), Avimelek can see that this is true of Avraham, so he seeks to make a covenant of peace with him.

In [Genesis 18:16-33](#), Avraham uses his privileged role to gain an audience with Yahweh and intercedes on behalf of the innocent in Sodom, asking God to spare the city, which he overlooks from a high place. In [Genesis 22:1-19](#), Avraham is called to a high place where he is to offer up the life of his son as a sacrifice that will intercede for his own sins (against Hagar and the kings).

These repetitions allow the narrator to compare and contrast each story with earlier precedents in the life of Avraham, creating more nuance in the developing portrait of God's chosen one.

Avraham Endangers Sarah, Again

The story is designed with three main parts: a brief introduction to the main narrative actions ([Gen. 20:1-2](#)) followed by a large center panel with two longer dialogues, the first between God and Avimelek ([Gen. 20:3-7](#)), and the second between Avimelek and Avraham ([Gen. 20:8-13](#)). The third unit concludes the story by resolving each element of Avimelek's conflict with Avraham, with Sarah, and with God ([Gen. 20:14-18](#)).

Macro Design of Genesis 20:1-18

Genesis 20:1-2

- a - Avraham journeys to Gerar
- b - He lies about Sarah
- c - She is taken by King Avimelek

Genesis 20:3-7

Double Dialogue Between Elohim and Avimelek

- **20:3, 5** "And Elohim came to Avimelek in a dream of the night and said ... In the blamelessness of my heart **I have done this thing** (עשיתי זאת)."
- **20:6** "And Elohim said to him in a dream ..."

Genesis 20:8-13

Double Dialogue Between Avimelek and Avraham

- **20:9** "And Avimelek called to Avraham and said ... What is it that **you have done to us** ?! (מה עשית לנו)"
- **20:10** "And Avimelek said to Avraham ..."

Genesis 20:14-18

- c - Avimelek returns Sarah to Avraham
- b - Avimelek compensates them for any damages
- a - Avraham leaves Gerar

Genesis 20:1-18 (Detailed). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The double dialogues and the longer conclusion are designed to highlight Avimelek's innocent motives in taking Sarah to be his wife. Each case of repetition or lengthening adds an element that makes Avimelek appear more righteous than Avraham.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 20:1-18

¹ And Avraham journeyed from there to the land of the Negev,
and he dwelt between Qadesh and between Shur,
and he was migrating in **Gerar**.

² And Avraham said about Sarah his wife,

“ **She is my sister** .”

And Avimelek king of **Gerar** sent
and he took Sarah.

Genesis 20:1-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The short introduction in Genesis 20:1-2 assumes the reader’s knowledge of the story in Genesis 12:10-20, so it abbreviates details that can be inferred from the earlier episode. Avraham’s motives and the reasons for his sojourn can be omitted because the narrator assumes the reader will fill in the gaps with knowledge from the parallel story. This also allows the narrator to give more space to the main focus of this story, which is the contrast between Avimelek’s integrity and Avraham’s self-protective deception.

³ And **Elohim came to Avimelek in a dream** of the night,
and he said to him,

“Look, **you are about to die** ,
on account of **the wife** whom **you took** ,
as she is married to a husband.”

⁴ Now, Avimelek had not gone near to her, and he said,

a “My master, would you **murder** a nation that is also **righteous** ?

b ⁵ Didn’t he say to me,

‘ **She is my sister** .’

b’ And she also said,

‘ **He is my brother** .’

a’ In the **blamelessness of my heart** and by the **innocence** of my hands **I have done this** !”

⁶ And **Elohim said to him in a dream** ,

“I do know that in the **blamelessness of your heart** **you have done this** ,
so I, yes I, withheld you from committing **moral failure** against me.
This is why I did not allow you to touch her.

⁷ **And now** , **return** **the wife of the man** ,

because he is a prophet,

and **he can pray** on your behalf so that **you can have life** .

And if you don’t **return** **her** ,

know that **you will certainly die** , you and all that belongs to you.”

a ⁸ And Avimelek rose early in the morning,

b and he called to all his **servants** ,

b’ and he spoke all these words in their ears,

and the **men** were **afraid (יִירָאוּ)** , very much.

⁹ And Avimelek called to Abraham, and said to him,

a “ **What is it you have done to us** ?!

b What **moral failure** have I committed against you,

b' that you have brought upon me and upon my kingdom this great **moral failure** ?!

a' **Doings that should not be done, that's what you've done to me** !”

¹⁰ And Avimelek said to Abraham,

“ **What** did you **see** (ראית) , that **you have done this thing** ?”

¹¹ And Abraham said,

“It's because I said,

‘Surely there is no **fear** (יראת) of Elohim in this place,

so they will **murder** me on account of **my wife**.’

¹² And also, **she truly is my sister** ;

she's the daughter of my father,

just not the daughter of my mother,

so she became **my wife**.

¹³ And it came about when Elohim made me wander from the house of my father,

then I said to her,

‘This can be the loyal love that you do for me:

in whatever place to which we go, say of me,

“ **He is my brother** .””

¹⁴ **And Avimelek took** flocks and cattle and slaves and **female slaves**,

and **he gave** them to Abraham,

and **he returned** to him **Sarah his wife**.

¹⁵ And Avimelek said,

“Look, my land is before you.

Dwell where it is **good in your eyes** .”

¹⁶ And to Sarah he said,

“Look, I give one thousand silver to your brother.

Look, it is for you **a covering of the eyes** for all who are with you,

and as for everything, you are thus beyond dispute.”

¹⁷ And **Abraham prayed** to Elohim,

and Elohim healed Avimelek,

and **his wife, and his female slaves**,

and they gave birth,

¹⁸ because Yahweh had fully-restrained every womb in the house of Avimelek,

on account of **Sarah the wife** of Abraham.

Avraham the Deceiver

In this story, Avraham replays his deception of a foreign king from the story in Genesis 12:10-20. And while his own motives and reasoning are omitted by the narrator, we are meant to infer them from the parallel story in Genesis 12.

In the intervening chapters, however, Avraham has become a more dimensional character. In Genesis chapters 14 and 18, we saw Avraham play a role in God's purposes among the nations. Specifically, Avraham is God's chosen vehicle to bring blessing on the nations, yet he persists in deceiving the nations and putting his own wife at risk. In Genesis 18:16-33, we also learned that Avraham has been invited into the divine council, so his intercession is accepted by God and can influence the divine will. Instead of asking God for help or deliverance in Gerar, Avraham resorts to his old schemes.

Avimelek the Righteous King

In contrast to Avraham, Avimelek is depicted as a normal ancient Near Eastern king who takes wives as he chooses. Because Avraham has forfeited his role as God's intercessor in this moment, God comes "directly" to Avimelek in a dream. The dialogue between God and Avimelek makes clever use of the intertwined "failure" narratives from Genesis 3-9 and also of Avraham's intercession in Genesis 18:16-33 by comparing and contrasting the characters in this story with those of earlier narratives.

Avimelek is Unlike Adam and Eve

Genesis 20: Avimelek	Genesis 2-3: Adam & Eve
Gen. 20:2 Avraham said of Sarah, "She is my sister." And Avimelek king of Gerar sent and took (לקח) Sarah.	Gen. 3:6 And the woman (האשה) saw (ראה) that good (טוב) was the tree for eating, and desirable to the eyes ... and she took (לקח).
Gen. 20:3 "Look, you are dead (מת), on account of the woman whom you took." Gen. 20:7 "... And if you don't return her, do that you will certainly die (מות תמות) ..."	Gen. 2:17 "From the tree of knowing good and bad you must not eat, because in the day you eat from it, you will certainly die (מות תמות)."
Gen. 20:6 God said to him ... "I did not allow you to touch/strike (נגע)."	Gen. 3:3 "From the tree that is in the middle of the garden we cannot eat from it or touch it (נגע)."
Gen. 20:9 : Avimelek called out to (ויקרא ... ל) Avraham and said " What have you done to us (מה עשית לנו)?"	Gen. 3:9 And Yahweh called out to (ויקרא ... אל) the man ...
<i>Avimelek Unlike Adam and Eve. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

Genesis 20: Avimelek	Genesis 2-3: Adam & Eve
	Gen. 3:13 And Yahweh said to the woman, "What is this you have done (מה זאת עשית)?"
Gen. 20:15 And Avimelek said, "Behold, my land is before you, dwell (ישב) in the good in your eyes (טוב בעיניך)."	Gen. 2:16 And Yahweh commanded (ויצו) the human ... Gen. 3:23 And Yahweh sent away (שלח) the human from the garden of Eden.
Gen. 20:16 "One thousand silver pieces ... let it be as a 'covering of the eyes' (כסות עינים) for you."	Gen. 3:5 "...in the day that you eat from it your eyes (עינים) will be opened ..."
Avimelek Unlike Adam and Eve. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Avimelek is depicted as similar to the woman “taking” from the forbidden tree, which in this case turns out to be a woman, Avraham’s wife.

Unlike the Eden narrative, where God warned the humans beforehand about the death-dealing effects of taking from the tree, here God can only offer the same warning after the fact. This difference from the Eden story highlights Avimelek’s innocent motives in taking Sarah to be in his harem, but now it places the moment of decision before him. Now that he has “taken” the forbidden fruit, he has a chance to give it back!

Notice the contrast in how the two stories end: In Genesis 3, the humans break the divine command, take the fruit, and they are exiled. In Genesis 20, Avimelek does wrong, but not by breaking the divine command. And after the matter is addressed, Avraham, the real wrongdoer, is allowed to stay in the land as if it’s a new Eden.

Avraham is Like Cain and God is Like God

Avraham	Cain
Gen. 20:4 And [Avimelek] said, “My master, would you really murder (הרג) a righteous nation? Didn’t he say to me, ‘She is my sister (אחות)’? And didn’t she say, ‘He is my brother (אח)’?”	Gen. 4:6 And Yahweh said to Cain, “Why is there hot anger to you? And why has your face fallen? ⁷ If you do good, won’t there be lifting up? and if you do not do good, at the door, moral failure (חטאת) is a croucher, and its desire is for you, but you can rule it.” ⁸ And Cain spoke to Abel his brother (אח), and it came about when they were in the field, and Cain rose up to Abel his brother (אח)
Gen. 20:9 And Avimelek called to Avraham and said, " What have you done (מה עשית) to us?! What was my moral failure (חטא) against you?! You brought upon me and upon my kingdom a	
Avraham Like Cain. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Avraham	Cain
great moral failure (חטאה) ! Doings that should not be done, that's what you've done (עשית) to me!"	and he murdered (הרג) him. ⁹ And Yahweh said to Cain, "Where is Abel your brother (אח) ?" and he said, "I do not know. Am I the keeper of my brother (אח) ?" ¹⁰ And he said, "What have you done (מה עשית) !?"
Gen. 20:11-12 And Avraham said, "It's because I said, 'Indeed there's no fear of Elohim in this place, and they will murder (הרג) me on behalf of my wife. And also, she really is my sister (אחות) ...'"	
<i>Avraham Like Cain.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

God comes to confront Avimelek about Avraham’s “sister,” just as he confronted Cain about his “brother.” But Avimelek’s innocent motives are on his side, so he appeals to God with a pure heart.

Avimelek accuses Avraham of acting like a careless Cain, whose “moral failure” regarding his so-called “sister” (spelled with same letters as “brother” in Hebrew) almost led to the “murder” of the innocent.

Cain's sin against his brother was the first step leading up to the flood. Avraham’s sin against Avimelek also leads to a severe flood-like judgment featuring the scarcity of wombs rather than the abundance of water (Gen. 20:18).

Avimelek Becomes His Own Intercessor

Avimelek in Genesis 20 20:4: "My master, would you really murder a righteous (צדיק) nation?!" 20:5: "In the blamelessness (תם) of my heart (לבב) and the innocence of my hands I did this!" 20:6: "I know that you did this in the blamelessness (תם) of your heart (לבב) ..."	Noakh in Genesis 6:5, 8-9 And Yahweh saw that multiplied was the badness of humanity in the land, and every purpose of the plans of his heart (לבב) was only bad all the day... But Noakh found favor in the eyes of Yahweh ... Noakh was a righteous one (צדיק), blameless (תם) in his generation; Noakh walked with Elohim ... Avraham in 18:23-25 And Avraham drew near, and said, "Are you really about to sweep away the righteous (צדיק) along with the wicked?" ... "Far be it from you to do such a thing, to put to death (מות) the righteous (צדיק) along with the wicked, so that the righteous (צדיק) and wicked become alike! Far be it from you! Shouldn't the justice-bringer of all the land do justice?"
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Avimelek, His Own Intercessor. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Avimelek makes the same appeal to God that Avraham did when he interceded for the righteous in Sodom. He appeals to God's justice, asking him to take account of the fact that Avraham deceived him. His "heart" was "blameless" unlike the generation of the flood whose "heart" was "only bad all the time" (Gen. 6:5).

And just as God accepted both Noah and Avraham's intercession, God acknowledges Avimelek's innocence and gives him a new command that will test his character: He must give Sarah back to Avraham.

Avraham's Prophetic Intercession for the Womb

Even though Avraham is a deceiver, he is God's deceiver, the one to whom God has made many promises. Notice that God does not abandon Avraham, but rather he intervenes to set right what Avraham did wrong, and then he directs Avimelek to go to Avraham for prayer and healing.

This is the first story of "healing" (רפא) in the Bible. Notice the connection between the key words and ideas here.

Genesis 20:7, 17 Instructor's Translation

⁷ And now, return the wife of the man,
because he is a prophet,
and he can pray on your behalf so that you can have life.
And if you don't return her,
know that you will certainly die, you and all that belongs to you."

...

¹⁷ And Avraham prayed to Elohim,

and Elohim healed Avimelek,
and his wife, and his female slaves,
and they gave birth,

Notice the parallel sequences of verbs.

- 20:7: **return the wife** > pray > **have life**
- 20:17: **return the wife** > pray > **healing and birth**

The story makes a close connection between the prophetic role of Avraham among the nations—their treatment of him will bring about either life or death, fertility or infertility, healing or sickness. And Avraham is given a privileged role among the nations, despite his deceptive behavior. This whole story explores the complicated role of God’s chosen people among the nations; the nations’ treatment of Avraham determines their fate.

17 **and Yahweh said,**

“Should I hide from Avraham **what I am about to do** ?

18 For Avraham will certainly become **a nation great** and powerful,
and **all nations** of the land will discover **blessing** through him;

19 Indeed, **I have known** him,

so that he would command his sons and his house after him,

that they should **keep the way of Yahweh,**

by **doing what is right and just**

so that Yahweh will bring upon Avraham what he has spoken about him.”

Genesis 18:16-33. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Prophetic Intercession and the Life of Eden

Avraham is given a privileged role as God’s prophetic-representative among the nations. This sets the paradigm for the role of the prophet that will continue to develop throughout the Hebrew Bible.

This concluding line also creates irony: Avraham was able to intercede for the infertile wombs of other people, but he never did this on behalf of his own wife. But now that he has done so, Sarah instantly becomes pregnant and gives birth (Gen. 20:1). This leads us directly into the next story.

Reflection Question

How do you reconcile the discomfort that arises when God continues to bless Avraham even when Avraham deceives and misuses others around him?